

Malak Entrance Story

The East Blue was often called the weakest of the seas, but to Malak, it was simply... inefficient. The air was softer, the threats lesser, but the chaos of human greed was a universal constant. His current objective, however, was an anomaly. The reports spoke of a "cybernetic humanoid creature," a description that clashed with the sea's rustic simplicity. His orders from the Black Hand command were characteristically succinct: *"Retrieve them and check in once you have them on the den den mushi."* No room for error, no tolerance for failure.

He found the scene in a dilapidated shipyard on the edge of a nameless island. The creature was exactly as described: a humanoid form of polished dark metal and faintly glowing blue seams, its arms bound in heavy sea stone shackles a precaution that spoke volumes about its presumed capabilities. Surrounding it was a gaggle of what could only be described as aspiring pirates, their gaudy colors and loud boasts marking them as the "less savory individuals" the briefing had so dryly noted. They were arguing loudly about their prize, debating whether to sell it to the Marines, a crime lord, or a "weird scientist" from the Grand Line.

Malak, clad in his signature dark, practical attire, felt a wave of profound weariness. Amateurs. He activated the power of the **Ashe Ashe Nomi (Ash-Ash Fruit)**. His body dissolved into a cloud of fine, black, smokey ash, streaming silently through a crack in the wall and materializing inside the circle of men, right next to the shackled being. The air grew cold, carrying the scent of ozone and cinders.

The pirates stumbled back, fumbling for their cutlasses. Malak ignored them entirely, his pale yellow eyes fixed on the captive.

"I need you to come with me," he said, his voice flat, devoid of request or threat. It was a statement of fact. "Will you come quietly?"

The being turned its head, a smooth, mechanical motion. A single blue optic lens focused on him. Its voice, when it spoke, was a calm, synthesized baritone. "I cannot. My current job is to be their captive."

Malak's eyebrow twitched, the barest flicker of emotion. A being bound by programming, by contract. He found an immediate, grim appreciation for this mindset. It was a logic he understood far better than the chaotic greed of the men around him.

"If you found yourself unemployed," Malak reasoned, his tone clinical, "would you then come with me?"

"I can only take on a new job once this one has been completed," it responded.

"Understood," Malak said. "Well, wait here then."

The scene that followed was not a battle; it was a systemic purge. The air filled with a choking, black haze as Malak's body became a vortex of ash. Tendrils of solidified soot, sharp as bone and cold as death, shot out from the cloud. They didn't cut; they *desiccated*, sucking the moisture and life from everything they touched, leaving behind skeletons stripped clean of flesh, which then crumbled into the growing pile of ash. Within moments, the raucous pirates were silent, their forms returned to the elemental dust from which they came.

All but one.

Malak materialized fully, his fingers clamped like vice around the throat of the gang's spindly, terrified leader. Smoky ash plumed from Malak's shoulders as he dragged the choking man forward and thrust him towards the captive being.

"Now," Malak instructed, his voice still dangerously calm, "would you kindly inform him that he no longer needs to be your captive? Do this, and you will be set free of us."

The small man, his eyes wide with primal terror, frantically sputtered, "Yes! Yes! You are done! You are fired from being our captive! This... this kind man is who we want to leave you in the care of! The job is over!"

The being inclined its head. "Yes, sir. It has been a pleasure being your captive." With a quiet, metallic *shriek*, the sea stone chains around its wrists snapped like dry twigs. It stood to its full height, an imposing figure of silent power.

The small man whimpered, turning his tear streaked face back to Malak. "See? There! He's yours now! Please, free me, like you said!"

Malak's gaze was impassive. "As you wish."

His free hand shot up, fingers turning jet black. Before the man could scream, ash poured from Malak's fingertips, not as a solid, but as a torrent of suffocating dust, forcing its way into the man's mouth, nose, and eyes. His muffled, gurgling screams were cut short as his body convulsed and then stilled, collapsing into a lifeless pile that was swiftly absorbed by the churning ash at their feet.

Malak turned his cool, assessing gaze to the being. "What is your name, and will you come quietly?"

"I do not have a name. And I will do what you ask of me until I have accomplished it."

Malak gave a slow, deliberate nod. He retrieved the den den mushi. Its face sluggishly morphed into the stern, efficient visage of Mira, the fleet's communications officer.

"I have achieved the objective," Malak reported. "Where do you want it?"

"Good job," Mira's filtered voice crackled. "New orders. I need you to check in on another group in the East Blue. Ensure they, and your current objective, make their way back to the fleet after accomplishing their objective."

Malak's jaw tightened almost imperceptibly. Babysitting. He despised inefficiency, and other Black Hand cells were notoriously... enthusiastic. "As you say," he replied, his tone frosty, before hanging up after receiving the coordinates and mission details.

He looked back at the nameless automaton, a tool of immense potential currently without a purpose. A tool needed a designation.

"I am going to call you Facade," Malak decided. "And your orders are to follow and prioritize my goals and objectives. Which, at this point, includes your well-being. Are we clear?"

Facade stood at a semblance of attention. "Yes, sir!"

Malak let out a slow breath, the ash around them finally beginning to settle, revealing the charred and barren landscape of the small island. The entire shipyard was now a monument of blackened, smokey ash.

"Well then," Malak said, turning towards the sea where a small, unmarked Black Hand sloop was hidden. "Let's go clean up someone else's mess. Hopefully, they are quiet."

The scene zoomed out, the two figures one of flesh and ash, the other of metal and mystery departing the scorched earth. Behind them, the island stood as a silent, grim testament to a 'mission accomplished'.